RESEARCH FRAMEWORK / COMPETITION

Competitor Comparison

A traceable comparison framework for public positioning, service descriptions, messaging, and observed differentiation.

01 Executive summary

A commissioned report would summarise the decision being considered, the scope examined, the most relevant evidence-backed observations, the main uncertainties, and the next decision points.

This illustrative document demonstrates a summary format only. It does not report actual market findings, verified organisations, client results, or recommendations about a real business.

* Decision question and intended audience
* Scope and evidence base reviewed
* Key observations with confidence and limitations
* Prioritised areas for further consideration

02 Illustrative research question

Which observable dimensions allow a team to compare a defined set of market alternatives without guessing at private strategy or performance?

03 Hypothetical context

Hypothetical demonstration: a team is reviewing how a proposed service could be described relative to a shortlist of alternatives. No real competitors or market claims are included.

DEMONSTRATION ONLY

No actual findings, clients, or sources are presented.

04 Scope and methodology

A live engagement would state the agreed market or organisation boundaries, geographic coverage, time period, included and excluded questions, source types, and analytical approach.

Research steps should be proportionate to the decision and evidence available. This demonstration describes a possible report structure, not research performed against real organisations or sources.

* Research question and decision context
* Scope, inclusion criteria, and exclusions
* Public and client-supplied evidence distinguished
* Review period and analysis approach

05 Findings and analysis

A completed report would distinguish observed information from analyst interpretation and hypotheses. Each material finding would be connected to evidence and assessed against the agreed question.

No real findings, comparisons, scores, market sizes, or business outcomes are asserted in this illustrative sample.

* Observed evidence and its source
* Interpretation and relevance to the decision
* Counter-signals, confidence, and open questions
* No unsupported statistics or inferred private performance

06 Evidence and source notes

For a real research engagement, a source log can record the publisher, title, publication date, retrieval date, URL or document reference, geographic coverage, relevant claim, and known limitations.

This demonstration intentionally does not cite external sources or present its example material as verified evidence.

* Publisher and source title
* Publication and retrieval dates
* URL or document reference and supported claim
* Source quality, coverage, and known limitations

07 Limitations and uncertainties

A research report should explain information gaps, source coverage, recency, conflicting claims, assumptions, and areas requiring further validation.

This illustrative document cannot establish actual demand, market size, competitor performance, partner willingness, or future results.

* Evidence gaps and unverified assumptions
* Source and geographic coverage
* Areas where additional research may be appropriate
* No guarantee of commercial or operational outcomes

08 Recommendations

Recommendations in a live report should follow from documented evidence and the agreed decision criteria. Their rationale, dependencies, and uncertainties should remain visible.

No real-world recommendations or outcomes are claimed in this illustrative document.

* Prioritised recommendations tied to the research question
* Evidence rationale and uncertainty for each action
* Dependencies, owners, or timing only where agreed

09 Proposed next steps

Potential next steps may include gathering additional evidence, testing a defined hypothesis, consulting relevant specialists, or reviewing specified indicators.

A live engagement would agree responsibilities, timing, and review points with the client. This demonstration does not claim that any action has been taken or that an outcome is assured.

* Identify the most important unresolved question
* Agree what additional evidence would help answer it
* Set proportionate review points and decision criteria
* Revisit conclusions as relevant evidence changes

10 Comparison brief and competitor set

Agree the business decision, intended audience, market boundary, geography, and the reason each organisation is included. Distinguish direct alternatives from adjacent substitutes and reference examples.

Record selection rules and exclusions before collecting evidence. A convenient list is not necessarily a representative competitor set.

* Define direct and adjacent alternatives
* Set an inclusion rule and review date
* Record relevant geographies and buyer contexts
* Note missing organisations and why they were excluded

11 Observable comparison dimensions

Compare what can be observed consistently in public materials. Potential dimensions include stated target audience, service categories, published process descriptions, public messaging themes, stated proof points, and visible calls to action.

Do not infer private pricing, actual sales performance, customer satisfaction, internal capabilities, or strategic intent unless separately evidenced and within scope.

* Published service and product descriptions
* Positioning language and stated audiences
* Publicly described methods and proof points
* Date and URL or document for every material observation

12 Evidence capture and confidence

Capture the exact public page or publication, its date where available, retrieval date, and relevant excerpt or paraphrase. Record when material is unavailable, ambiguous, or apparently outdated.

Use confidence notes to explain evidence completeness, not to suggest statistical certainty. A missing public statement should be recorded as not observed, rather than as evidence that the competitor does not offer a capability.

* Consistent source log across all organisations
* Observed fact distinguished from analyst interpretation
* Unknown or unobserved values left explicit
* Potential conflicts or stale material flagged

13 Matrix and synthesis

Build a comparison matrix using the agreed dimensions and source references. Add a short synthesis that identifies recurring language, visible areas of differentiation, and questions for the commissioning team.

Avoid arbitrary league tables or unsupported scoring. If criteria are prioritised, explain who selected them and how that prioritisation relates to the business decision.

* Comparison matrix with source references
* Themes across public positioning
* Differentiation hypotheses to test
* Questions for customer or stakeholder validation

14 Illustrative synthesis format

A practical output may show each observation, its source, its relevance to the decision, and any uncertainty. This example does not name organisations, report their actual positioning, or claim a competitive gap exists.

Recommendations should describe options for further consideration and validation, not promise that a specific positioning will win customers.

* What appears consistently in the reviewed materials
* What is distinctive only within this selected set
* What remains unknown from public information
* What additional evidence could test an opportunity

15 Limitations and potential outputs

Public communications are not a full account of a business. Websites can change, messages may be tailored to particular buyers, and stated offers do not establish actual delivery or outcomes.

Potential outputs include a competitor matrix, a source register, positioning observations, limitations, and recommendations for further validation.

* No private or confidential competitor information is assumed
* No performance or customer-result claims are inferred
* Coverage is limited to agreed organisations and sources
* Research reflects the review period